

Practice Quiz: Communication — How Brains Connect

Part A: Multiple Choice

1. Communication in active inference is the process of: A) Copying your thoughts directly into someone else's brain B) Trying to share your mental model by encoding thoughts into signals that the other person decodes C) Saying words and hoping for the best D) Always agreeing with everyone

Answer: B — You encode your ideas into signals (words, tone, emoji), and the receiver decodes them using their own models.

1. Why does the word "fine" cause miscommunication between you and your parent? A) "Fine" isn't a real word B) Your mental model of "fine" is different from your parent's mental model of "fine" C) Parents never listen D) You're always lying

Answer: B — The same word gets decoded differently because each person's model assigns it a different meaning.

1. Text messaging makes miscommunication worse because: A) Phones are unreliable B) Texts strip away tone, facial expressions, and body language, forcing your brain to fill gaps with predictions C) Nobody knows how to type D) Texts are always sarcastic

Answer: B — Without nonverbal cues, your brain has to guess the sender's intent — and those guesses depend on your own mood.

1. If you're feeling insecure and someone texts "lol sure," you'll probably read it as: A) Friendly and casual B) Sarcastic or dismissive, because your mood shapes your prediction C) A love letter D) A grocery list

Answer: B — Your current emotional state shapes the predictions your brain makes about ambiguous messages.

1. Sarcasm almost never works in text because: A) Nobody is funny over text B) Sarcasm relies on tone of voice, which text doesn't have, so the receiver's brain can't tell you're joking C) Sarcasm is wrong D) Autocorrect fixes sarcasm

Answer: B — Without tone cues, the receiver's brain has no way to predict that you meant the opposite of what you typed.

1. A good communicator thinks about: A) Only what they want to say B) How their message will be received based on the other person's model C) Speaking as fast as possible D) Using the most complicated words

Answer: B — Effective communication means minimizing the gap between what you mean and what the listener predicts you mean.

1. "Check understanding" means: A) Quiz the other person B) Ask questions like "Does that make sense?" to make sure your message landed correctly C) Assume you were perfectly clear D) Repeat yourself ten times

Answer: B — Checking understanding reduces the prediction gap between sender and receiver.

1. When you get a text that makes you feel a strong emotion, the best first step is to: A) Immediately fire back an angry response B) Pause and ask "Am I reacting to what they said, or to what my brain predicted they meant?" C) Block the person D) Screenshot it and share with everyone

Answer: B — Separating the actual message from your brain's prediction helps you respond to reality, not assumption.

1. Important conversations should happen in person when possible because: A) In-person is cheaper B) Face-to-face gives your brain more data (tone, face, body language) for accurate predictions C) Texting is illegal D) People can't lie in person

Answer: B — More data means more accurate predictions about what the person actually means.

1. Writing code comments for your future self is like communication because: A) Code is a language B) You're reducing the prediction error the future reader will experience by aligning their mental model with yours C) Computers read comments D) Comments make code run faster

Answer: B — Comments help the next reader predict what your code does without having to reverse-engineer it.

Part B: Short Answer

1. Find a text conversation where something got misunderstood. What did the sender mean? What did the receiver's brain predict? Where was the gap?
2. Explain why the same emoji can mean completely different things to different people. How does this relate to different mental models?
3. Describe a situation where choosing the wrong medium (text instead of in-person, or vice versa) made a conversation go wrong. What would have worked better?
4. How could you use the strategy of "consider their model" before having a difficult conversation with a friend? What would you think about first?
5. Give an example of a time when being a better receiver (pausing before reacting) could have changed how a conversation went for you.